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Teylers Museum Online Catalog: Systematic Quality Analysis

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Management Summary

An AI-assisted analysis of **84 objects** from Teylers Museum's online catalog (https://teylers.adlibhosting.com) has identified **approximately 279 major errors** and over **400 minor omissions**. Not a single object was found to be free of errors or significant omissions.

The objects span the museum's full breadth: prints, drawings, medals, coins, fossils, minerals, scientific instruments, and rare books. The findings are not isolated incidents but reveal **structural quality problems** in the online catalog:

- **Factual errors** in dates, attributions, techniques, and biographical data
- **Missing descriptions** — many objects have no description at all
- **Missing context** — makers, authors, and depicted persons are listed as bare names without identification
- **No cross-references** between related objects (e.g., instrument suites, print series)
- **Reference catalogs not cited** (e.g., Turner & Levere 1973 for instruments, Van Loon for medals)
- **Inscriptions not translated** — Latin, Greek, and Dutch inscriptions go unexplained
- **Rarity and significance not indicated** — objects worth millions are described identically to common pieces

The error rate of **approximately 3.3 major errors per object** is consistent across all phases of analysis. Extrapolated to the full collection, this points to **thousands of major errors** awaiting correction.

Even the museum's own "Topstukken" — its 50 most important objects — are afflicted. We have now analyzed **49 of the 50 Topstukken** directly (only FK 0014 remains pending) and found **major errors in every single one**. The highlights of this expanded analysis are devastating:

- A **gold medal worth ~€65,000 in bullion alone** is attributed to a maker who died **21 years before the medal was struck**. Nicolaas van Swinderen (1705–1760) is listed as the creator of a 1781 Doggersbank medal. He was dead.
- **The most expensive book in the world** — Audubon's *Birds of America*, a copy of which has sold for $8.8 million at Christie's — is described as having "5 volumes." The correct number is 4. The catalog also misidentifies Audubon's birthplace (Haiti, not France), his age when he came to America (18, not 20), and omits that the Teylers copy is the only double elephant folio in the Netherlands.
- The **obverse and reverse of a VOC disaster medal** (TMNK 01297) are **transposed** — every description of "front" and "back" is inverted compared to the Rijksmuseum's identical exemplar.
- A **Peace of Breda medal** (TMNK 00741) describes the figure trampled by Hollandia as "Medusa (Charles II)." The figure is Discord (Discordia). The medal caused a diplomatic incident with England; the Dutch States ordered the dies destroyed. None of this appears in the catalog. The survival of this medal is extraordinary.
- **Beringer's Lügensteine** — 18th-century deliberate forgeries, one of the most celebrated cases of scientific fraud in history — are classified as "FossilSpecimen" in the Teylers catalog. They are not fossils. They are carved limestone fakes.
- The **first mosasaur ever found** (F 07424-01) is described with a single word: "kaak" (jaw). Its discovery in 1764 is placed at the "ENCI quarry," an institution that was not established until 1926.
- **Isaac Newton (died 1727)** is listed as a co-creator of a telescope built in 1790.
- The **lamp inventor's 12-year-old son** (H.P. Maxim) is listed instead of the father (H.S. Maxim) for a collection of first-generation electric lamps from 1881. Three of the five named lamp makers in the same record have name errors.

The AI methodology demonstrated here is **scalable to the entire collection at approximately €4 per object** — a fraction of the cost of traditional art-historical research. A complete collection scan would transform the quality and accessibility of Teylers' online catalog.

Disclaimer

This analysis was conducted by Joost Soeterbroek, who is not an art historian or museum professional. All findings are based exclusively on **publicly accessible online metadata** from the Teylers Adlib/Axiell catalog system, cross-referenced with publicly available scholarly sources, museum databases (Rijksmuseum, British Museum, Museo Galileo, Harvard, Museum Boerhaave, Royal Museums Greenwich, Smithsonian), academic publications, and reference works.

It is possible that Teylers' internal collection management system contains additional fields, annotations, or corrections not published in the online catalog. If so, the question arises: why are these corrections not reflected in the public catalog? The online catalog is the museum's primary interface with the world — researchers, students, journalists, and the general public depend on it.

All detailed analysis reports are available in the public GitHub repository: https://github.com/jsoeterbroek/teylers_collection_research

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Scope

Three random samples plus targeted Topstukken phases, totaling **84 objects analyzed**:

Phase	Objects	Collection areas	Major errors
Sample 1	13	Prints, drawings, medals, coins, instruments, sculpture	28
Sample 2	15	Rare books, scientific instruments	20
Sample 3	7	Fossils, coins, medals, rare books, instruments	12
Topstukken — Art Phase 1	8	Paintings, drawings, prints (art collection)	16
Topstukken — Art Phase 2	7	Paintings, drawings, prints	~34
Topstukken — Art Phase 3	7	Drawings, prints, books	36
Topstukken — Art Phase 4 (Sample 3 additions)	5	Drawings, paintings	~26
Topstukken — Books	4	Rare books	~13
Topstukken — Instruments	8 (of 9; FK 0014 pending)	Scientific instruments	~45
Topstukken — Fossils & Minerals	10	Fossils, minerals, geological specimens	~38
Topstukken — Coins & Medals	3	Medals, coins	9

Phase	Objects	Collection areas	Major errors
TOTAL	**87 records / 84 objects**	**All major collection areas**	**~279**

Average: **~3.3 major errors per object**. Objects with zero errors: **0**.

Of the **50 "Topstukken"**, **49 have been analyzed** — the complete Art category (21 objects), all 5 Books Topstukken, 8 of 9 Instruments Topstukken (FK 0014 pending), all 12 Fossils & Minerals Topstukken, and all 3 Coins & Medals Topstukken. Every single analyzed Topstuk contains major errors.

Analyzed Objects

Sample 1: Prints, Drawings, Medals, Coins, Instruments

#	Object	Type	Period
1	PP 0121 — Samuel van Hoogstraten, *Portrait of Adriaen Blyenburg*	Print	c. 1660
2	TvB G 0771 — Abraham Blooteling, *The poet Jan Vos*	Print	c. 1661–1662
3	KG 01153 — Karel Dujardin, *Landscape with sheep and cow*	Print	c. 1658
4	KG 04733 — Marcus de Bye, *Title page with fountain*	Print	c. 1659
5	FK 0002 — Standard measuring rod	Instrument	c. 1820
6	FK 0007 — Spirit level calibration device	Instrument	c. 1820
7	FK 0011 — Thomas Earnshaw, Chronometer	Instrument	c. 1835–1837
8	N 021 — Equestrian statue of Marcus Aurelius (bronze)	Sculpture	1778–1790
9	KG 07880 — Johannes Jelgerhuis, *New Brewers' Creek at Overveen*	Print	c. 1793
10	KT 2001 103 — Jan Gerard Waldorp, *Landscape with town and water*	Drawing	c. 1777–1806
11	KT 2001 106 — Jan Gerard Waldorp, *Two women*	Drawing	c. 1785–1790
12	TMNK 00002 — Johannes Huss medal	Medal	c. 1700–1740
13	TMNK 00009 — Eleonora / Frederick III medal	Medal	c. 1600–1650

Sample 2: Rare Books and Scientific Instruments

#	Object	Type	Period
14	63 — Alexander Aphrodisiensis, *De Fato*	Book	1658
15	68 — Ammonius, *De adfinium vocabulorum Differentia*	Book	1739
16	394 — O. Herz, Beresovka mammoth expedition report	Book	1902
17	407 — C.A. Crommelin, Catalogue of scientific instruments Leiden	Book	1926
18	2163 — G. Cuvier, *Histoire des progrès des sciences naturelles*	Book	1826–1828
19	3163 — J. Baster, *Natuurkundige Uitspanningen*	Book	1759–1765
20	FK 0027 — Inclined plane, after ’s Gravesande	Instrument	1750–1774
21	FK 0018 — Stand with two pulleys, Kampman & Pelletier	Instrument	1775–1799
22	FK 0020 — Pulleys, Kampman & Pelletier	Instrument	1775–1799
23	FK 0022 — Five tackle blocks (no maker listed)	Instrument	1775–1799
24	FK 1996.01 — Sound analyser, after Koenig	Instrument	c. 1872
25	FK 1980 01 — Van der Bildt reflecting telescope	Instrument	c. 1745–1791
26	FK 1973.01 — Kistemaker ultracentrifuge model	Instrument	1957
27	FK 1241 — Solar microscope by J. Mortier	Instrument	1776
28	FK 1159 — “Electric barometer” (actually electroluminescence demonstrator)	Instrument	1790

Sample 3: Fossils, Coins, Medals, Books, Instruments

#	Object	Type	Period
29	F 06928 — *Ostromia crassipes* (formerly “Archaeopteryx”)	Fossil	~150 Ma
30	F 08432 — *Homo diluvii testis* (giant salamander)	Fossil	~13 Ma

#	Object	Type	Period
31	TMNK 00272 — Prince's thaler, Holland 1584	Coin	1584
32	TMNK 00294 — Capture of Breda medal (Peat Barge)	Medal	1590
33	TMNK 10564 — Gold striking of a quarter guilder	Coin	1692
34	1020 — Marcus Aurelius *Meditations* (Gataker edition)	Book	1697
35	FK 0073 — Cycloidal track, Kampman & Steitz	Instrument	1750–1774

Sample 3 Additions: Drawings, Paintings, and a Drawing

#	Object	Type	Period
36	KT 1989 096 — Anon., *Portrait of August Schmidt*	Drawing	1899
37	KS 013 — Johannes Jelgerhuis, *Interior of the Nieuwe Kerk, Delft*	Painting	1825
38	KS 052 — Nicolaas Pieneman, *The attack by Juan de Jáuregui on Prince Willem I*	Painting	1838
39	N 039 — Hendrick Goltzius, *Portrait of Jacques de la Faille*	Drawing	c. 1580
40	U 004 — Rubens after Titian, *Saint Jerome in the Wilderness*	Drawing	c. 1600–1629

Topstukken — Art (21 objects, all analyzed)

Phases 1–3 covered 21 art Topstukken including works by Michelangelo, Raphael, Rembrandt, Rubens, and other masters. Details in analysis reports.

Topstukken — Books (5 objects, all analyzed)

#	Object	Type	Period
56	WBW 08140 — John James Audubon, *The Birds of America*	Book	1827–1838
57	12162 — Reinier & Josua Ottens, *Atlas Major*	Book	c. 1725–1750
58	12494 — Sydney Parkinson, *A Journal of a Voyage to the South Seas*	Book	1784

#	Object	Type	Period
59	WBW 15370 — Ventenat & Redouté, *Jardin de la Malmaison*	Book	1803–1805
(previous)	(Diderot & d'Alembert *Encyclopédie* — analyzed in prior phases)	Book	1751–1772

Topstukken — Instruments (8 of 9 analyzed; FK 0014 pending)

#	Object	Type	Period
60	FK 0181 — Solar collector with steam piston (after Mouchot)	Instrument	1879
61	FK 0219 — Gasometer for hydrogen combustion (Van Marum / Fries)	Instrument	1790–1791
62	FK 0275 — Phonautograph (Koenig / Scott de Martinville)	Instrument	1865
63	FK 0310 — Heliostat after Klinkerfues (Meyerstein, Göttingen)	Instrument	1865
64	FK 0323 — Seven-foot reflecting telescope (William Herschel)	Instrument	1790
65	FK 0508 — Large electrostatic generator with Leyden jars (Van Marum / Cuthbertson)	Instrument	1783–1784
66	FK 0624-01 — First-generation electric lamps in wooden rack	Instrument	1881–1882
67	FK 1790-01 — Wedgwood Queen's Ware distillation vessels	Instrument	c. 1790

Topstukken — Fossils and Minerals (12 objects, all analyzed)

#	Object	Type	Period
29	F 06928 — *Ostromia crassipes* ("Archaeopteryx")	Fossil	~150 Ma
30	F 08432 — *Homo diluvii testis* (giant salamander)	Fossil	~13 Ma
68	F 07424-01 — *Mosasaurus hoffmanni* jaw (first mosasaur found)	Fossil	72–66 Ma

#	Object	Type	Period
69	F 16266 — Woolly mammoth skull, Heukelum	Fossil	~31,000 BP
70	F 16269 — Cave bear skeleton (*Ursus spelaeus*)	Fossil	~24,000 BP
71	F 16390 — Beringer Lügensteine (deliberate forgeries, 1725)	Non-fossil	1725
72	M 00605 — Malachite specimen (Ural Mountains)	Mineral	18th c. collection
73	M 01518 — Rock crystal cluster (Dauphiné, France)	Mineral	c. 1802 acq.
74	M 01524 — Stibnite crystal (Ichinokawa Mine, Japan)	Mineral	19th c. acq.
75	M 03353 — Rock from the summit of Mont Blanc (De Saussure, 1787)	Geological	1787 coll.
76	M 11800 — Collection of Haüy crystal models (565 pieces)	Scientific models	1802–1804 acq.
77	M 12369 — Maquette Mont Blanc (Exchaquet, 1787)	Model	1787

Topstukken — Coins and Medals (3 objects, all analyzed)

#	Object	Type	Period
78	TMNK 00741 — Peace of Breda medal (Adolphi, 1667)	Medal	1667
79	TMNK 01297 — VOC Gouden Buys disaster medal (1695)	Medal	1695
80	TMNK 02269 — Battle of the Doggersbank gold medal (1781)	Medal	1781

The Topstukken Test

Teylers Museum has itself designated **50 objects as "Topstukken"** — the highlights of the collection, presented on its website at teylersmuseum.nl/nl/ontdek/topstukken. These are the objects the museum considers most important: works by Michelangelo, Rembrandt, and Raphael; the large electrostatic machine; the Mosasaurus; the *Ostromia* fossil; Audubon's *Birds of America*.

We have now analyzed **49 of these 50 Topstukken**. Every single one contains major errors. None is free of significant omissions. The average error rate among the Topstukken is **higher** than across the random samples — because the Topstukken represent objects that attract more scholarly attention, making discrepancies more discoverable through cross-referencing.

If the museum's own crown jewels are not accurately described, there is little reason to expect the broader collection to be correctly cataloged.

Top Findings: The Most Compelling Discoveries

These are the most striking individual findings across all 84 analyzed objects. Each represents a case where the catalog record either contains an outright factual error that a modern researcher would immediately detect, or omits context that fundamentally changes the meaning of the object.

1. TMNK 02269: The Medal Maker Died 21 Years Before the Medal Was Made

The Teylers catalog attributes this 1781 Doggersbank gold honor medal to **Nicolaas van Swinderen (1705–1760)** as medailleur. Van Swinderen died on 3 July 1760 — more than twenty-one years before the Battle of the Doggersbank took place on 5 August 1781. He cannot physically have made this medal. The related commemorative medal type is attributed by the Rijksmuseum and Royal Museums Greenwich to **Johan Georg Holtzhey (1726–1808)**. The Teylers attribution is chronologically impossible. This medal is also extraordinary for its size: at 90.58 mm diameter and 811 grams, it is one of the largest and heaviest gold medals in Dutch 18th-century history. It was awarded posthumously to the family of Captain Bentinck, who died of his wounds 19 days after the battle. None of this appears in the catalog.

2. TMNK 01297: Obverse and Reverse Are Transposed

The Teylers catalog describes the obverse (front) of this 1695 VOC disaster medal as the ship in the bay, and the reverse (back) as the scene of survivor Lourens Veyselaer among the Khoikhoi. The Rijksmuseum's record for the identical medal (NG-VG-1-4373) explicitly identifies the opposite assignment: the survival scene is the obverse, the ship scene is the reverse. Every description of "front" and "back" in the Teylers record is inverted. Additionally, the catalog misidentifies Dirk Schelte (who composed the inscriptions) as the maker of the medal — the actual medailleur is anonymous. The issuing body is listed as "Dutch Republic — Holland Province" when it was the VOC Chamber of Enkhuizen.

3. TMNK 00741: "Medusa" is Actually Discord — and the Catalog Omits the Diplomatic Incident

The Teylers catalog describes the figure trampled underfoot by Hollandia on this 1667 Peace of Breda medal as "Medusa (Charles II)." The figure is **Discord (Discordia)** — a standard allegorical personification, not Medusa and not a portrait. The Rijksmuseum identifies the same figure in their identical exemplar as Discord. More critically, the catalog makes no mention of the medal's extraordinary political aftermath: the motto *"PROCUL . HINC . MALA . BESTIA . REGNIS"* (Be gone, pernicious beast, from our realms) was understood by King Charles II as a personal insult; the British government formally protested; the Dutch States of Holland apologized and **ordered the dies destroyed**. That this medal survives is evidence that some strikes were made before suppression — making its very existence historically remarkable. The catalog is silent on all of this. This medal came from Pieter Teyler van der Hulst's personal collection.

4. F 16390: Beringer's Lügensteine Cataloged as "FossilSpecimen"

The Teylers catalog classifies the Lügensteine — the infamous 18th-century **deliberate limestone forgeries** planted to deceive the Würzburg palaeontologist Johann Beringer in 1725

— under the object category **"FossilSpecimen."** The catalog's own "Object name" field correctly says "Fossil, imitated," which directly contradicts the "FossilSpecimen" category. These are not fossils. They are carved fakes, constituting one of the most celebrated cases of scientific fraud in history. The catalog also uses the "Scientific name" field to record "Lügensteine (Liegstenen)" — a German/Dutch colloquial name for the hoax stones — as if it were a Linnaean binomial. The description field is entirely blank.

5. F 16269: Cave Bear — Wrong Taxonomic Authority, Wrong Extinction Date, Composite Skeleton Undisclosed

The catalog gives the authority for *Ursus spelaeus* as "Blumenbach." The correct authority is **Rosenmüller, 1794**. This is not a minor bibliographic point: Rosenmüller described the species in his 1794 Leipzig doctoral thesis; Blumenbach described other Pleistocene megafauna but not the cave bear. The age is listed as "ca. 20,000 years ago," when modern scientific consensus places cave bear extinction at approximately **24,000–28,000 years ago**. Most significantly, the Teylers topstukken page itself states that this is a **composite skeleton** assembled from bones of multiple individuals found together in Moravian caves — a fact entirely absent from the formal catalog record.

6. F 07424-01: First Mosasaur Ever Found — Described in One Word, Placed at a Quarry Established 162 Years After the Discovery

The description of this jaw fragment — the **first mosasaur specimen ever recovered**, found in Maastricht in 1764 and foundational to both vertebrate palaeontology and the concept of biological extinction — consists of a single Dutch word: **"kaak"** (jaw). The collection locality is listed as including "ENCI quarry." The ENCI cement quarry was not established until **1926** — an anachronism of 162 years for a specimen found in 1764. In 1764 the fossils came from an underground chalk mine. The species spelling (*hoffmannii* vs. *hoffmanni*) also contradicts a 2024 peer-reviewed nomenclatural note co-authored by a **Teylers Museum staff member**.

7. FK 0624-01: The Lamp Inventor's 12-Year-Old Son, a Premature Aristocratic Title, and a Garbled Name

Three of the five named lamp makers in this record of first-generation electric lamps (1881) contain errors. **"H.P. Maxim"** (Hiram Percy Maxim, 1869–1936) was 12 years old in 1881; the Paris exhibitor was his father **H.S. Maxim** (Hiram Stevens Maxim, 1840–1916). **"von W. Siemens"** uses the "von" particle granted to Werner Siemens by Emperor Friedrich III in **1888** — seven years after the exposition. In 1881 he was simply Ernst Werner Siemens, and the lamps were a product of the firm Siemens & Halske. **"van der E. Ven"** is a garbled transcription: the initial "E." has been placed in the middle of the surname, producing a nonsensical string. The correct name is **Elisa van der Ven** (1833–1909), curator of the Physical Cabinet, who purchased the lamps at the Paris exposition and published the first Dutch scientific study of incandescent lamps.

8. FK 0219: Lavoisier Listed as Inventor of an Instrument He Did Not Make

The catalog lists Antoine Lavoisier as the "inventor" of FK 0219, a gasometer designed by **Martinus van Marum** and built by instrument maker Fries in Haarlem in 1790–1791. Lavoisier invented the original gasometer concept; Van Marum's version was an explicit redesign and simplification. Additionally, the object name "verbrandingstoestel" (combustion apparatus) misidentifies the instrument type: it is a **gasometer** — a device for storing and measuring gas. Van Marum published its description in *Verhandelingen van Teyler's Tweede Genootschap* Vol. 10 (1798) — entirely absent from the bibliography. The record also has no dimensions, no provenance, and a one-sentence description that merely restates the title.

9. FK 0323: Isaac Newton (Died 1727) Listed as Co-Creator of an 1790 Telescope

The Teylers catalog lists **Isaac Newton (1642–1727)** as "inventor" in the same creator field as William Herschel (who actually built this instrument in Slough in 1790) and Frédéric Guillaume Fries. Newton died 63 years before this telescope was made. He invented the Newtonian reflecting telescope *type* in 1668 — not this instrument. The catalog's own Dutch website correctly uses "naar Isaac Newton" (after Newton). The record also lacks dimensions, provenance, and any description, despite this being a designated Topstuk. It was purchased directly by Teylers director Van Marum from Herschel during a personal visit to Slough in 1790 — an event entirely absent from the record.

10. M 11800 (Haüy Crystal Models): The Catalog Undercounts the Models by 15

The Teylers catalog and topstukken page state this collection contains **550 crystal models**. The definitive scholarly study — Wim Saeijs, *Mineralogical Record*, Vol. 39 No. 5 (2008) — established that **565 of the original 597 models survive at Teylers**, making this the most complete Haüy crystal model collection in the world. The catalog also incorrectly states these models are from the "18th century" — they were made and acquired in **1802–1804** (19th century). The direct catalog URL for this object redirects to the Axiell search homepage rather than displaying the record. There is no photograph in the online catalog.

11. WBW 08140 (Audubon's *Birds of America*): The World's Most Expensive Book Has the Wrong Volume Count

The Birds of America was named the most expensive book ever sold at auction, achieving $8.8 million at Christie's New York in 2002. The Teylers copy — the only complete double elephant folio first edition in the Netherlands, acquired by direct subscription between 1827 and 1838 at a cost of 2,243 guilders (more than director Van Marum's annual salary) — is described in the catalog as having **"5 volumes."** The correct number is **4 volumes**. The five-volume figure appears to confuse the plates (bound in 4 volumes) with the companion text, *Ornithological Biography* (published in 5 volumes). The catalog also misidentifies Audubon's birthplace (Haiti, not France), misstates his age at arrival in America (18, not 20), and omits entirely the work's status as the world's most expensive book, the approximately 120 surviving complete copies worldwide, and the presence of records of now-extinct species.

12. KT 1989 096: Wrong Images Shown, Subject Misspelled, "Freiheitskmämpfer" is a Nonsense Word

Images 01 and 02 linked to this record of a portrait drawing of August Schmidt — the last survivor of the Battle of Waterloo — are confirmed by EXIF metadata to show **entirely different objects** (KT 1989 084 and KT 1989 083v). The subject's surname is misspelled as "Smidt" in the subject index tag, impairing discoverability. The inscription field records "Freiheitskmämpfer" — an impossible German compound with an inserted 'k'. The inscription on the drawing reads "Freiheitskämpfer." Schmidt died in 1899 at age 104; the catalog records a contradictory notation "102" in the inscription field while correctly noting "104-jarige" in the title. The technique is misidentified as "zwart krijt" (black chalk) when the drawing is in graphite pencil.

13. FK 0508: Viervant's Death Year Is Wrong, and the Machine's Date Range Is Unexplained

The Teylers large electrostatic generator — the world's largest flat-plate frictional electrostatic machine ever built — lists its co-designer **Leendert Viervant** with a death year of **1802**. All authoritative sources (Wikipedia, Wikidata) confirm his death date was **4 July 1801**. The

production date "1783–1791" is not explained: the machine was complete and in use by **Christmas Day 1784** (as the catalog's own date free-text confirms), and the machine's own inscription reads MDCCLXXXIV (1784). The "1791" refers to the last known modification — an eight-year discrepancy unexplained in the record.

Structural Problems

These problems affect the catalog as a whole, not merely individual objects:

1. Missing Descriptions

Many objects — particularly scientific instruments and minerals — have no description field at all. The catalog assumes the title is self-explanatory. Titles such as "Electric barometer," "Solar microscope," or "Stibnite crystal" tell a modern visitor nothing about what the object does, why it matters, or how it works. Across the 84 analyzed objects, at least 20 had no functional description.

2. No Cross-References Between Related Objects

The catalog treats each object in isolation. In reality many form coherent groups: - The **Kampman workshop suite** (FK 0014, 0018, 0020, 0022, 0027, 0073): 's Gravesande mechanics demonstrations - Van Marum's **electrical discharge research programme** (FK 0508, 1153, 1159) - The **telescope collection** (FK 0323, 0324, 1980 01): English and Dutch makers - The **Mont Blanc ensemble** (M 03353 + M 12369): together documenting the 1787 De Saussure expedition - Print **series** (KG 04733 is a title page of an 8-plate series) - Medal **series** (TMNK 00009 from a documented Prague series)

3. Makers, Authors, and Depicted Persons Not Contextualized

Names are listed without any identification. The visitor sees "Moritz Meyerstein, Göttingen" and learns nothing. Meyerstein was the principal Mechaniker at Göttingen University's physics institute, supplying instruments to its scientific departments. This pattern repeats with virtually every named person in the catalog.

4. Reference Catalogs Not Cited

Standard numismatic reference works (Van Loon, Dugniolle, Betts) are absent from medal records. The definitive instrument catalog (Turner & Levere, *Martinus van Marum: Life and Work*, Vol. IV, 1973) is never cited. Print references (Hollstein, Bartsch) are inconsistently applied.

5. Inscriptions Not Translated

Latin, Greek, and early Dutch inscriptions are transcribed but not translated. Powerful texts such as *"PROCUL . HINC . MALA . BESTIA . REGNIS"* remain unexplained. This excludes the great majority of visitors from understanding the objects.

6. Mineralogical and Geological Records Systematically Incomplete

All mineral records lack chemical formulae, crystal systems, IMA-approved names, and hardness data. The "production date" field — designed for manufactured objects — is applied to

minerals and geological specimens, creating a fundamental category error across the entire mineral collection. "Production date: 18th century" for a Ural malachite specimen implies the mineral was made in the 18th century; it should say "collected / acquired."

7. Digital Asset Management Errors

At least one record (KT 1989 096) displays photographs of entirely wrong objects, confirmed by EXIF metadata. The catalog URL for M 11800 (Haüy crystal models) redirects to the Axiell homepage. Several objects have no photographs despite being publicly displayed.

Error Classification

By Category (All 84 Objects)

Category	Count	Examples
Factual errors (dates, attributions, techniques)	~65	TMNK 02269 maker died 21 years prior; F 16269 wrong taxonomic authority; FK 0323 Newton listed as 1790 co-creator
Missing or inadequate descriptions	~35	F 07424-01 described in one word; FK 0310 no description; M 01518 no description
Missing context / significance	~55	TMNK 00741 diplomatic incident; WBW 08140 world's most expensive book; FK 0624-01 Paris 1881 context
Missing or incorrect makers / authors	~40	FK 0624-01 H.P. Maxim vs H.S. Maxim; 12494 editor Lettsom absent; 12162 Josua Ottens omitted
Missing provenance / acquisition history	~50	F 07424-01 entire discovery/acquisition chain; M 12369 contested provenance unresolved
Missing cross-references	~10	Kampman suite; Mont Blanc ensemble; telescope collection
Digital/image errors	~5	KT 1989 096 wrong images; M 11800 broken URL and no image
Mineralogical / geological classification errors	~20	F 16390 "FossilSpecimen"; M 00605 "Siberia" for Ural Mountains; all minerals missing chemical formulae
Total major errors (estimated)	**~279**	

By Collection Area

Collection	Objects	Major errors	Avg. per object
Prints & Drawings	12	40	3.3
Paintings	2	9	4.5
Medals & Coins	10	22	2.2
Scientific Instruments	21	78	3.7
Rare Books	10	28	2.8
Fossils	7	26	3.7
Minerals & Geological Specimens	8	22	2.75
Scientific Models	2	8	4.0
Sculpture	2	4	2.0
Total	**84**	**~279**	**~3.3**

Complete Error Register

Sample 1: Major Errors (28)

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
PP 0121	Subject classification wrong	medicus	jurist / magistrate / regent
PP 0121	Technique wrong	engraving	etching
PP 0121	Death date discrepancy	1639 (on print)	1630 (historical)
TvB G 0771	Birth year wrong	1622	c. 1626
TvB G 0771	Technique anachronistic	etching and stipple engraving	etching — “stipple engraving” is anachronistic for 17th century
TvB G 0771	Maker’s role wrong	engraver	etcher
TvB G 0771	Date too broad	1642–1678, ca.	c. 1661–1662
KG 01153	Technique wrong	etching	engraving
KG 01153	Technique/role contradictory	engraver + etching	engraver + engraving
KG 01153	Birth year Dujardin wrong	1622	c. 1626
KG 04733	Maker’s role wrong	engraver	etcher
KG 04733	Series not identified	not stated	Title page of “Animals” series (8 plates)
FK 0002	Transcription error	“Egnelse”	“Engelse”
FK 0002	Transcription error	“Amsgterdamsche”	“Amsterdamsche”
FK 0007	Material possibly wrong	glass, brass	brass, ivory/bone; glass not visible

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
FK 0011	Date wrong	c. 1840	c. 1835–1837
FK 0011	Materials incomplete	glass, brass	mahogany, brass, glass, enamel, ivory
N 021	Provenance incomplete	Odescalchi heirs, 1790	Queen Christina of Sweden □ Odescalchi (1692) □ Teylers (1790)
KG 07880	Date too broad	c. 1770–1822	c. 1790–1795 (probably c. 1793)
KG 07880	Technique incomplete	etching	etching and engraving
KT 2001 103	Date too broad	c. 1770 – before 1828	c. 1777–1806
KT 2001 106	Date too broad	c. 1770 – before 1828	c. 1785–1790
TMNK 00002	Date catas-trophically wrong	1415	c. 1700–1740 (1415 is an inscription date, not manufacture)
TMNK 00002	Maker wrong	Kingdom of Bohemia, unknown	Workshop of Christian Wermuth, Gotha
TMNK 00002	Place wrong	Bohemia (implied)	Germany (Gotha/Thuringia)
TMNK 00009	Series not identified	not stated	"Judenmedaille" — Prague series, c. 1600–1650
TMNK 00009	Title misleading	"Marriage… 1452"	Not a marriage medal; dynastic portrait from a series
TMNK 00009	Birth year of Eleonora wrong	1436	1434

Sample 2: Major Errors (20)

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
63	Second author absent	Alexander only	Ammonius Hermiae is second author — book contains two texts
68	Authorship un-differentiated	"Ammonius"	Modern scholarship: Herennius Philo of Byblos
394	Significance absent	minimal record	Landmark primary source: official Beresovka mammoth report
407	Significance absent	minimal record	Founding catalogue of Rijksmuseum Boerhaave
2163	Author not identified	"G. Cuvier"	Baron Georges Cuvier, founder of comparative anatomy; visited Teylers 1811

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
2163	Nature of work unexplained	title only	Official report on scientific progress, commissioned by Napoleon
2163	Cuvier-Teylers connection absent	not stated	Cuvier identified *Homo diluvii testis* as giant salamander at Teylers
FK 0018	Makers not contextualized	names only	Kampman workshop; two partnerships over 50 years; part of suite
FK 0018	Suite not cross-referenced	isolated record	Part of 's Gravesande mechanics suite
FK 0020	Inconsistent maker name	"Jean Pelletier"	"J.C. Pelletier" (same as FK 0018) — same person
FK 0020	Death year as "?"	"?"	Probably 1780 (documented engraver Jean C. Pelletier)
FK 0022	No maker listed	—	Almost certainly Kampman & Pelletier (identical to FK 0018/0020)
FK 0022	Pedagogical series not recognized	isolated record	Third in pulley ☐ block ☐ tackle series
FK 1980 01	"(1663)" misleading	in title	1663 = Gregory's design year, NOT construction date (c. 1745–1791)
FK 1980 01	Van der Bildt dynasty not identified	"J. v.d. Bildt, Franeker"	550+ telescopes; curator of Franeker University
FK 1980 01	Dual-system not stated	not mentioned	Gregorian + Cassegrain modes in one telescope
FK 1973.01	Kistemaker was Teylers curator	not stated	Explains acquisition; important for institutional history
FK 1241	No description	—	World's first projector: projects microscopic images with sunlight
FK 1159	No description; title misleading	"Electric barometer"	NOT a barometer — demonstrates electroluminescence; precursor to neon lamp
FK 1159	No maker	—	Probably John Cuthbertson, Amsterdam (Van Marum's instrument maker)

Sample 3: Major Errors (12)

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
F 06928	Date strongly wrong	165–45 million years ago	~150 Ma (Late Jurassic, Tithonian)
F 06928	Classification outdated	"oervogel" (primitive bird)	*Ostromia crassipes* since 2017 — NOT a bird
F 08432	Date far too broad	23–5 million years ago	~13 Ma (Middle Miocene, Serravallian)
F 08432	Cuvier's re-identification not described	not stated	Cuvier visited Teylers 1811, exposed forelimbs, proved it was a salamander
TMNK 00272	Murder context absent	only "1584"	William of Orange assassinated 10 July 1584; possibly posthumous portrait
TMNK 00272	Coin type not identified	"helmeted reichsthaler"	Should identify as "prinsendaalder" — standard numismatic term
TMNK 00294	Peat barge story not described	title only	Dutch Trojan Horse: soldiers hidden in peat barge; one of the most famous Dutch military exploits
TMNK 10564	Extreme rarity not stated	"[gold striking]" only	Possibly unique; comparable pieces auctioned for €180,000–€245,000
1020	"Cornelio Stanhope" probably wrong	"Cornelio Stanhope"	Almost certainly George Stanhope (1660–1728), Dean of Canterbury
1020	Gataker not identified	not stated	Thomas Gataker (1574–1654); his edition is "the principal authority" on the *Meditations*
FK 0073	No description	title only	Demonstrates brachistochrone and tautochrone — two of the most elegant results in classical mechanics
FK 0073	's Gravesande not mentioned	not stated	Built to design of 's Gravesande (1688–1742), foremost promoter of Newtonian physics

Sample 3 Additions: Major Errors (~26)

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
KT 1989 096	**Wrong objects shown in images 01 and 02**	Images 01–02	EXIF confirms images show KT 1989 084 and KT 1989 083v
KT 1989 096	**"Freiheitskmämpfer" is nonsense word**	Freiheitskmämpfer	Freiheitskämpfer (freedom fighter)
KT 1989 096	**Name misspelled "Smidt"**	Smidt	Schmidt
KT 1989 096	**"102" contradicts all known facts**	"102" in inscription field	104 (born 11.02.1795, died 12.09.1899)
KT 1989 096	**Technique wrong**	zwart krijt (black chalk)	Graphite pencil
KS 013	**Creator name missing "Rienksz."**	Johannes Jelgerhuis	Johannes Rienksz. Jelgerhuis — contradicts the painting's own inscription "Rz"
KS 013	**No provenance**	Not recorded	Acquisition context, date, price
KS 013	**No description**	Not recorded	Choir of Nieuwe Kerk; De Keyser mausoleum; staffage figures
KS 013	**Mausoleum designer absent**	Not mentioned	Hendrick de Keyser (1614–1621), completed Pieter de Keyser (1623)
KS 013	**No exhibition history**	Not recorded	Including Haarlem 1825
KS 052	**Title omits central protagonist**	"De aanslag door Jean Jauregui op Prins Willem I"	Full title with Maurits commanding examination of Jáuregui's body
KS 052	**Date typo "1852" in related record KG 08154**	"18 maart 1852"	"18 maart 1582"
KS 052	**No description**	Empty	Multi-figure scene with Maurits, Willem I, Charlotte, soldiers, Jáuregui
KS 052	**No provenance**	Not recorded	Likely direct acquisition / commission, 1838
N 039	**"Gravure gedateerd 1580" in a drawing record**	References print's date	c.1580, preparatory to the engraving

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
N 039	**Subject birth date missing**	Only "gest. 1615"	c.1548–1615
N 039	**Artist nationality absent**	Not recorded	German-born; Dutch by career (Haarlem from 1577)
U 004	**Attribution debate with Van Dyck concealed**	"Rubens, tekenaar"	Attribution contested; Van Dyck connection in bibliography unexplained
U 004	**Which Titian not identified**	"kopie naar Tiziano Vecellio"	Which of 4+ versions (Louvre c.1531; Brera c.1552; Escorial c.1575)
U 004	**No date**	Not stated	c.1600–1608 (Italy) or c.1628–29 (Madrid)
U 004	**No provenance**	Not stated	Possibly 1790 Odescalchi/Christina of Sweden purchase
U 004	**No description**	Not stated	Composition, pose, mixed-media technique
U 004	**Bibliography without citations**	Titles only	Authors, years, publishers, page numbers

Topstukken — Books: Major Errors (~13)

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
WBW 08140	**Volume count wrong**	5 volumes	4 volumes (standard binding of Havell edition)
WBW 08140	**Lizars's role misrepre-sented**	Plates 1–10 by W.H. Lizars only	All 10 retouched and aquatinted by R. Havell Jr.; R. Havell Sr. also omitted
WBW 08140	**Scientific/cultural significance absent**	Not stated	World's most expensive book; $8.8M Christie's 2002; only copy in Netherlands; ~120 survivors worldwide
12162	**Josua Ottens omitted as co-author**	Reinier Ottens only	Reinier AND Josua Ottens — contradicted by own publisher field
12162	**Composite/factice nature absent**	"boek"	Atlas factice — custom-assembled; no two copies identical
12494	**Plate count wrong**	"29 colored and engraved views"	27 plates (portrait and maps counted separately)
12494	**"Waller" does not exist**	"Commanders Waller, Carteret…"	Captain Samuel Wallis (1728–1795)

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
12494	**Title truncated**	Short title only	Full title including ship Endeavour, Parkinson's role, appendix
12494	**Edition not recorded**	Not stated	Second edition (first edition: 1773)
12494	**Editor Lettsom absent**	Not mentioned	John Coakley Lettsom (1744–1815) edited the 1784 edition
WBW 15370	**Illustration technique wrong**	"lith." (lithography)	Stipple engravings printed à la poupée — not lithography
WBW 15370	**Plate count catastrophi-cally wrong**	6 plates	120 plates (20 fascicles × 6); or undisclosed incomplete copy
WBW 15370	**Publication date truncated**	1803-1804	1803–1805 (complete November 1805)

Topstukken — Instruments: Major Errors (~45)

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
FK 0181	**Pifre labeled "inventor"**	uitvinder	Mouchot's assistant; not co-inventor
FK 0181	**Description = title repeated**	Title verbatim	Physical description of dish, boiler, piston, operation
FK 0181	**No dimensions**	Not recorded	Dish ~48 cm diameter
FK 0181	**No provenance**	Not recorded	Purchased 1879, following 1878 Exposition Universelle
FK 0219	**Lavoisier listed as inventor of this object**	Antoine Lavoisier, inventor	Inventor of original concept only; FK 0219 is Van Marum & Fries's redesign
FK 0219	**Object name misidentifies instrument type**	verbrandingstoestel	Gasometer (gazometer) for hydrogen combustion
FK 0219	**No dimensions**	Not recorded	Essential for identification and comparison
FK 0219	**No provenance**	Not recorded	Commissioned 1790 by Van Marum; Fries recruited from London specifically
FK 0219	**Description is one non-informative sentence**	Restates title	What it is, how it works, scientific significance

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
FK 0219	**No bibliography**	Not recorded	Van Marum *Verhandelingen* Vol. 10 (1798); Turner & Levere Vol. IV (1967)
FK 0275	**Production date conflates acquisition and manufacture**	"1865 (exact)"	Manufacture: c.1859–1865; Acquired: 1865 — must be separate
FK 0275	**Horn material absent**	hout, ijzer	Also: zinc/tin-plate horn with white enamel interior
FK 0275	**No description**	Empty	World's first sound recording device; visual-only; cannot play back
FK 0275	**Maker "R. Koenig" insufficient**	R. Koenig, Parijs	Karl Rudolph Koenig (1832–1901), Prussian-born, Paris
FK 0275	**Inventor truncated; 1857 patent date absent**	E.L. Scott de Martinville	Édouard-Léon Scott de Martinville (1817–1879); patented 25 March 1857
FK 0310	**Maker's full name absent**	Meyerstein, Göttingen	Moritz Meyerstein (1820–1901), Mechaniker, University of Göttingen
FK 0310	**Klinkerfues not identified**	Klinkerfues	Ernst Friedrich Wilhelm Klinkerfues (1827–1884), astronomer, director Göttingen Observatory
FK 0310	**No description**	Empty	Heliostat: clock-driven mirror for stable solar beam; Klinkerfues design
FK 0310	**Mirror absent from materials**	messing, mahonie	Also: speculum metal or silvered glass mirror — primary optical component
FK 0310	**No provenance**	Not recorded	Acquisition date, agent, cost unrecorded
FK 0310	**Klinkerfues design publication not cited**	Not recorded	*Astronomische Nachrichten* — establishes what "naar Klinkerfues" means
FK 0323	**Newton listed as co-creator of 1790 instrument**	Isaac Newton (1642–1727), inventor	"naar Isaac Newton" — type inventor 122 years prior; no involvement in this instrument

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
FK 0323	**No description**	Empty	Newtonian reflecting telescope; octagonal mahogany tube; speculum mirror ~155 mm
FK 0323	**No dimensions**	Not recorded	Tube ~2100 mm; mirror aperture ~155 mm
FK 0323	**Fries role unexplained**	instrumentmaker (same as Herschel)	Maintenance/adaptation role; not the builder
FK 0323	**No provenance**	Not recorded	Purchased directly from Herschel by Van Marum, Slough 1790
FK 0508	**Viervant death year wrong**	1802	1801 (died 4 July 1801, Amsterdam)
FK 0508	**Viervant role misleading**	"designer" (same level as Van Marum)	Architect of wooden support/cabinetwork only; not scientific co-designer
FK 0508	**Date range 1783–1791 unexplained**	1783-1791	Machine complete 1784; 1791 = last modification; own text confirms this
FK 0508	**Leyden jar battery not described**	"Leidse flessen" in title only	~100 jars, 4 sets; largest Leyden battery ever assembled
FK 0508	**No description**	Empty	World's largest flat-plate electrostatic generator; ~330 kV; first observation of ozone (1785)
FK 0624-01	**Wrong Maxim**	H.P. Maxim (son, age 12 in 1881)	Hiram Stevens Maxim (1840–1916) — H.S.
FK 0624-01	**Wrong Lane-Fox surname**	G. Lane-Fox (pre-1880 form)	St. George Lane Fox-Pitt (post-May 1880 form)
FK 0624-01	**"von W. Siemens" anachronistic**	von W. Siemens	Ernst Werner Siemens / Siemens & Halske; "von" not granted until 1888
FK 0624-01	**"van der E. Ven" garbled**	van der E. Ven	Elisa van der Ven (1833–1909)
FK 0624-01	**Van der Ven role understated**	onderzoeker (researcher)	Curator; acquirer at Paris 1881; tester; author of first Dutch study of incandescent lamps
FK 0624-01	**No provenance**	Not recorded	Purchased at First International Exposition of Electricity, Paris, 1881

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
FK 0624-01	**No description**	Not recorded	~20 bulbs; shapes; filament types; rack; manufacturer labels
FK 0624-01	**1881 exposition context absent**	Not mentioned	Paris 1881; committee ranking; five competing lamp systems
FK 0624-01	**Van der Ven 1882 publication not cited**	Not recorded	First Dutch scientific study of incandescent lamps
FK 1790-01	**Material contradicts title**	aardewerk (generic)	Queen's Ware / creamware — already named in the title
FK 1790-01	**No description**	Empty	Number of vessels, forms, Wedgwood marks, condition
FK 1790-01	**No dimensions**	Not recorded	Essential for physical identification
FK 1790-01	**No provenance**	Not recorded	Acquisition from Wedgwood for Van Marum's 1790 chemistry laboratory
FK 1790-01	**No bibliography**	Not recorded	Turner & Levere, *Martinus van Marum* Vol. IV (1967) is the definitive source

Topstukken — Fossils and Minerals: Major Errors (~38)

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
F 07424-01	**Species spelling wrong**	*hoffmannii*	*hoffmanni* (Schulp et al. 2024, co-authored by Teylers staff)
F 07424-01	**Description = one word**	"kaak"	Full description of historic significance and anatomy
F 07424-01	**Provenance absent**	Not given	Drouin 1766, Van Marum 1784, French confiscation attempt 1795
F 07424-01	**Geological formation absent**	Not given	Maastricht Formation, Maastrichtian Stage type section
F 07424-01	**Collection place anachronism**	ENCI quarry (est. 1926)	Underground chalk mine, Sint Pietersberg, Maastricht, 1764
F 16266	**Geographic locality wrong**	"Heukelom, Z v.Gennep/Maas : ZLi"	Heukelum, Gelderland (Linge valley), not Limburg/Gennep area

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
F 16266	**Scientific name authority absent**	Not given	*(Blumenbach, 1799)*
F 16266	**Description absent**	Not given	Largest complete mammoth skull in the Netherlands; 43-year-old male
F 16266	**Provenance absent**	Not given	Van Wilgen 1820; Hollandsche Maatschappij 1824 for 2,755 guilders; Teylers 1885
F 16269	**Wrong taxonomic authority**	*Ursus spelaeus* Blumenbach	*Ursus spelaeus* Rosenmüller, 1794
F 16269	**Age understated**	ca. 20,000 years ago	ca. 24,000–28,000 years ago (before Last Glacial Maximum)
F 16269	**Composite nature not disclosed**	Not mentioned	Skeleton assembled from multiple individuals (stated on Teylers' own topstukken page)
F 16269	**Description absent**	Not given	Herbivorous bear, composite skeleton, size data, extinction context
F 16390	**Object category wrong**	FossilSpecimen	Fabricated object / imitated fossil — NOT a fossil specimen
F 16390	**Scientific name field misused**	"Lügensteine (Liegstenen)"	Field should be blank or N/A — not a taxon
F 16390	**Description absent**	Not given	Carved limestone slab; context of the Beringer hoax; 18th-century scientific fraud
M 00605	**Geography wrong**	"Siberia"	Ural Mountains — NOT Siberia; Urals are the Europe/Asia boundary
M 00605	**Provenance absent**	Not given	Van Berkhey collection ☐ illustrated in Houttuyn (1761–1785) ☐ acquired by Van Marum after 1795
M 00605	**Description absent**	Not given	Mineralogical description, formula Cu☐(CO☐)(OH)☐, botryoidal banding, 18th-century Ural mine

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
M 01518	**Scientific name obsolete**	Cristal de roche (18th-c. trade name)	Quartz, SiO□ (IMA-approved)
M 01518	**"Production date" wrong for a mineral**	circa 1802 (as if manufactured)	Acquisition date: c. 1802; geological age: Cenozoic
M 01524	**Scientific name obsolete**	Antimoine sulfure	Stibnite, Sb□S□ (IMA-approved)
M 01524	**French Prefecture misspelled**	Echime Prefecture	Ehime Prefecture
M 03353	**"Creator" applied to a natural specimen**	Horace-Bénédict de Saussure (onderzoeker)	Collector: Horace-Bénédict de Saussure (1740–1799), 3 August 1787
M 03353	**Chlorite described as coating**	"overtrokken met chloriet"	Chloritised biotite (in situ metamorphic replacement)
M 11800	**Model count incorrect**	550 models	565 models (per Saeijs, *Mineralogical Record* 2008)
M 11800	**Catalog URL broken**	Redirects to homepage	Direct URL should display object detail
M 11800	**No image**	No photograph	Collection of this significance requires photography
M 11800	**Production period wrong**	18th century	Models made and acquired 1802–1804 (19th century)
M 12369	**Dimensions absent**	absent	approx. 100 × 64 × 35 cm
M 12369	**Materials absent**	absent	Swiss stone pine, plaster, ground quartz, paint
M 12369	**Scale absent**	absent	1:15,000
M 12369	**Provenance unresolved**	absent	Acquired 1799; purchased by Van Marum (9 guilders) or donated by Govert Lups — needs resolution

Topstukken — Coins and Medals: Major Errors (9)

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
TMNK 00741	**Trampled figure misidentified**	Medusa (Charles II)	Discord (Discordia); "Mala Bestia" was an allusion to Charles II, not a portrait

Object	Error	Teylers says	Should be
TMNK 00741	**Diplomatic incident absent**	Not mentioned	Dies ordered destroyed after English diplomatic protest; medal a stated casus belli for 1672 war
TMNK 00741	**Reverse inscription incomplete**	REDIIT . CONCORDIA . MATER . BREDAE . AO . 1667	Includes "IUL . 31" date — treaty date of 31 July 1667 is in the exergue
TMNK 01297	**Obverse and reverse transposed**	Obverse = ship; Reverse = Veyselaer/Khoikhoi	Obverse = Veyselaer/Khoikhoi scene; Reverse = ship (per Rijksmuseum)
TMNK 01297	**Maker misidentified**	Dirk Schelte — maker	Dirk Schelte — inscription author only; medailleur is anonymous
TMNK 01297	**Issuing authority incorrect**	Dutch Republic — Holland Province	VOC Kamer Enkhuizen (VOC Chamber of Enkhuizen)
TMNK 02269	**Maker died 21 years before medal was struck**	Nicolaas van Swinderen (1705–1760)	Johan Georg Holtzhey (1726–1808) is maker of related type; or uncertain/anonymous
TMNK 02269	**Issuing authority incorrect**	Dutch Republic — Holland Province	Staten-Generaal — explicitly named in the medal's own title
TMNK 02269	**Posthumous nature not stated**	Not mentioned	Bentinck died 24 August 1781 (19 days after battle); medal received posthumously by his family

(The complete error register for Topstukken Art phases 1–3 is available in the previous summary version 20260307 and in the individual analysis reports.)

Methodology

Each object was analyzed through the following process:

1. **Catalog retrieval**: The Teylers Adlib/Axiell catalog page was fetched and all metadata fields extracted
2. **Deep research**: An AI research agent performed systematic cross-referencing with:
   - Other museum databases (Rijksmuseum, British Museum, Museo Galileo, Harvard, Museum Boerhaave, Royal Museums Greenwich, Smithsonian, V&A)
   - Academic publications and reference works
   - Biographical dictionaries and Wikipedia/Wikidata
   - Specialist numismatic, art-historical, and scientific instrument databases
   - Mineralogical databases (Mindat, IMA, GBIF)
   - Digitized primary sources (e-rara, BHL, EEBO, HathiTrust, Gallica)
3. **Analysis report**: A detailed markdown report was written per object with all findings

4. **Error classification**: Errors were classified as Major (factually wrong, significantly misleading, or essential information absent) or Minor (missing context, untranslated inscriptions, uncited references)

The complete process — from catalog retrieval to final reporting — was conducted by a single researcher (Joost Soeterbroek) assisted by the Claude Opus 4.6 AI model (Anthropic). Analysis time per object ranged from 10 to 45 minutes, averaging approximately 20 minutes per object.

What a Full Collection Scan Would Deliver

Based on the results of this pilot study, a systematic scan of Teylers' complete online catalog would:

- **Identify an estimated 3,000+ major errors** in the collection (based on the ratio of ~3.3 errors per object)
- **Prioritize corrections** by severity and public impact (Topstukken first, then frequently accessed objects)
- **Generate enriched descriptions** for objects currently lacking any description
- **Map cross-references** between related objects, making hidden stories and connections visible
- **Produce a comprehensive correction report** directly importable into the catalog system
- **Cost approximately €4 per object** — orders of magnitude less than traditional art-historical research
- **Be completed in weeks, not years** — the AI methodology scales linearly

The pilot has already demonstrated the methodology on 84 objects across all major collection areas. The infrastructure, prompts, and quality standards are proven. Scaling to the full collection is a matter of execution, not experiment.

AI Compute Resources

Resource	Estimate
AI model	Claude Opus 4.6 (Anthropic)
Total tokens processed	~12,000,000
Research agent calls	~180
Web fetches	~250
Estimated compute cost	~€350–€420
Total analysis time	~8 sessions, ~28 hours

The cost of analyzing 84 objects with AI assistance (~€385) compares favorably with equivalent manual art-historical research, which would require days of specialist time per object. **Scaled to a full collection scan, this methodology could assess thousands of objects at a fraction of traditional costs.**

Recommendations

1. **Commission a systematic full collection scan** using AI-assisted methodology to identify errors and omissions across the entire online catalog

2. **Begin with the 50 Topstukken** — the museum's own crown jewels deserve error-free catalog records; only FK 0014 remains to be analyzed in the current study
3. **Correct the immediate critical errors identified** in this report — particularly the impossible attributions (TMNK 02269 maker died 21 years prior; FK 0323 Newton listed as 1790 co-creator), misclassifications (F 16390 Lügensteine as FossilSpecimen), transposed descriptions (TMNK 01297 obverse/reverse), and the wrong images on KT 1989 096
4. **Add description fields** to all objects lacking descriptions, particularly scientific instruments, minerals, and medals
5. **Implement cross-references** between related objects (suites, series, provenance groups, thematic ensembles)
6. **Contextualize all named persons** with brief biographical notes and dates
7. **Translate all inscriptions** into Dutch and English
8. **Update mineralogical records** to IMA-approved mineral names, chemical formulae, and crystal system data
9. **Resolve the "production date" problem** across the mineral and fossil collections — distinguish geological age from collection date from acquisition date
10. **Cite standard reference catalogs** (Turner & Levere, Van Loon, Hollstein, Betts, Mindat, GBIF, etc.) consistently
11. **Link to external digital surrogates** where available (EEBO, BHL, Rijksmuseum, etc.)
12. **Audit the digital asset management system** for cross-linked images and broken catalog URLs

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Statistical Summary

Metric	Sample 1	Sample 2	Sample 3	S3 Additions	Top. Art	Top. Books	Top. Instruments	Top. Fossils/Min.	Top. Coins/Medals	**Total**
Objects analyzed	13	15	7	5	21	4	8	12	3	**84**
Major errors	28	20	12	~26	~86	~13	~45	~38	9	**~279**
Major errors per object	2.2	1.3	1.7	~5.2	~4.1	~3.3	~5.6	~3.2	3.0	**~3.3**
Objects with zero errors	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	**0**
Minor omissions	~50	~60	~40	~25	~105	~20	~45	~50	~15	**~410**

Conclusion

The analysis of 84 objects — including 49 of the museum's 50 designated Topstukken — from Teylers Museum's collections reveals a **consistent pattern of quality problems** in the online catalog. With approximately 279 major errors across 84 objects and not a single error-free record, the evidence points strongly to systemic problems.

The findings range from the mundane (missing dates, bare names without identification) to the extraordinary: a medal attributed to a maker dead for 21 years; a portrait drawing that links to photographs of entirely different objects; the world's most expensive book given the wrong volume count; forged fossil fakes classified as genuine fossil specimens; a cave bear skeleton assembled from multiple individuals without that fact being disclosed; and a telescope attributed to Isaac Newton despite having been built 63 years after his death.

The methodology demonstrated here — AI-assisted cross-referencing of catalog records with scholarly databases, museum collections, and reference works — is fast, scalable, and cost-effective. At approximately **€4 per object**, a complete collection scan is economically feasible and would deliver dramatic improvements in catalog quality.

Teylers Museum manages one of the world's most important heritage collections. The online catalog should reflect that status. The findings in this report are offered as a constructive contribution to that goal — and as a demonstration that the tools to achieve it are available today.

This report was produced by Duinroos Innovatie using AI research (Claude Opus 4.6, Anthropic). All findings are based on publicly available sources and cross-references with other museum collections. Individual analysis reports for all 84 objects are available at https://github.com/jsoeterbroek/teylers_collection_research.

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